3. Stanley Finds Livingstone

— Lawrence Wilson

Abouth the author

David Livingstone was born in 1813 in Scotland to very religious parents. A Scottish missionary cum explorer, he was different from other missionaries and other explorers. He decided to explore the dark interiors of Africa and find out the source of the river Nile. He wanted to evangelize less and explore more and accepted the assignment from Royal Geographical Society in 1865. Though hampered by bouts of malaria and dysentery, he managed to find a number of water bodies. At one point there were rumours that he was dead as there was no sign of his whereabouts. In 1869, nearly four years after he was sent, *New York Herald* sent Stanley on an assignment to Ujiji near Lake Tanganyika to find David Livingstone.

About the text

This extract is from Lawrence Wilson's *Stanley Finds Livingstone*. It graphically describes the travails faced by Stanley in his attempt to find Livingstone. Stanley undertook the expedition after fully equipping himself with arms, ammunitions, bales of cloth, tents, medicines, money and coloured beads (native equivalent of money). There were five caravans in all and they had to pass through nearly 750 miles. Stanley faced every kind of problem including sickness, pillage and mutiny. At the end of all the traumatic experiences, Stanley found Dr. Livingstone. Approaching Livingstone, Stanley spoke the famous words 'Dr. Livingstone, I presume.' Livingstone received him with kindness and Stanley's report of his meeting became one of the biggest journalistic scoops.

Reading

Late on an October night in 1869, James Gordon Bennett, Jr., son of the elderly proprietor of the *New York Herald,* was in his bedroom at the Grand Hotel, Paris, when there was a knock on the door and a short, frowning, ugly young man presented himself.

"Who are you?" asked Bennett.

"My name is Stanley."

"Ah, yes." This was the special correspondent whom Bennett had summoned from covering the civil war in Spain. "Where do you think Livingstone is?" he said, coming straight to the point.

"I really don't know, Sir."

"Do you think he is alive?"

"He may be and he may not be."

"Well I think he is alive and I am going to send you to find him."

So began one of the most challenging journalistic assignments ever issued. Livingstone, the famous medical missionary and explorer who had penetrated almost one-third of unknown Africa and whose career was followed eagerly by millions in England and the United States, was thought to be somewhere in the middle of the Dark Continent—if he was alive. He had gone to Africa for the third time in 1865, starting from Zanzibar towards the interior and for the last four years no white man had set eyes on him. Rumours came that he had been murdered, but were disproved by letters from him. Then absolute silence fell and for the last twelve months Livingstone's whereabouts, his state of health, his activities had caused anxious conjecture. Here Bennett had seen his chance for a scoop and in Stanley the man to make it.

"Do what you think best," he told him, "but find Livingstone," and added money was no object. If the expedition cost more than a thousand pounds, then he must draw another thousand and when that was finished, another, and then another. **"But find Livingstone."**

With these words ringing in his ears Stanley left Paris and however astute, Bennett could never have realized just how well he had chosen his man. Stanley had a strong American twang and called himself an American citizen, but he was not. He had been born in Denbigh, North Wales, in 1841, the illegitimate son of Elizabeth Parry, a butcher's daughter and John Rowlant, a farmer. Neither parent would have anything to do with him and at six the unwanted child had been dumped into the terror and loneliness of a workhouse run by a sadistic ex-miner. Years

of ill-treatment ended when the boy struck back one day, left his tormentor unconscious and fled to relatives who gave him odd jobs till, aged seventeen, he sailed as a cabin boy from Liverpool to New Orleans.

In the States the youth was unofficially adopted by a kindly merchant, Henry Morton Stanley, who gave him fatherly affection and his name, but died soon after. Stanley fought for the Confederates in the American Civil War, served as a seaman in merchant ships and the federal navy, then was taken on by the *New York Herald* as special correspondent covering the British campaign in Abyssinia. Burning in him was an urge to prove himself by outstanding achievement and so he accepted by a hostile world, and the assignment to find Livingstone was just what he needed; a clear-cut task, a chance for heroism, the prospect of fame if he succeeded. That he knew nothing of the African jungle, nothing of how to handle natives, nothing—except what his imagination conjured—of the dangers he would meet merely added to the challenge.

In January, 1871, having covered meanwhile the opening of the Suez Canal and travelled for his paper as far as Karachi, he was facing his first difficulties in Zanzibar. As a point to aim for he chose Ujiji, a place on the eastern shore of Lake Tanganyika, where Livingstone had been last heard of. But that was nearly 750 miles from the coast and to get there a massive expedition would be needed. No money had come from Bennett and Stanley had only eighty pounds in his pocket. But thanks to his zeal and powers of persuasion, he managed to borrow a large sum from the American consul, taking care to conceal the real object of his journey.

Within the short space of a month Stanley had organized his expedition. He decided to take supplies to last two years—arms, ammunition, clothing, tents, medicines, cooking utensils—food as much as could be carried and the native equivalent of money in the form of coloured beads, rolls of cloth and wire. The beads were a problem: most tribes would accept only certain shapes and colours. Black beads were valued in one area, useless in another. Egg-shaped ones were acceptable in Ujiji, only red in

Unyamwezi. Taking what advice he could, Stanley spent eight thousand dollars on "currency", knowing that without it tribal chiefs would refuse to let him pass through their territory and the expedition might starve.

Finally, with everything packed into seventy-pound loads that could be carried on the head, the supplies weighed over six tons. As porters, two hundred Zanzibaris were engaged and two white men, both ex-merchant navy, to help supervise; a number of donkeys were bought. The whole party sailed for the mainland in March and at Bagamoyo on the coast more porters had to be hired. This took time and before the expedition could start— split into five "caravans" with Stanley bringing up the rear—the rainy season with its mud and swollen rivers was almost on them.

But all were in high spirits as they set off, taking their women and cattle with them, the men singing at the top of their voices, the column guide waving the American flag and Stanley in white flannels and solar helmet cavorting on a bay horse to laughter and cheers from the locals.

There were various routes into the interior, but being in a hurry and "possessed by the power to achieve," Stanley chose to go due west and unwittingly took the hardest. The country was open savannah and under the rains soon turned to a bog. Temperatures were colossal, sometimes reaching 128 degrees, and there were myriads of insects which attacked men and animals and brought devastating fevers.

So the march was hard enough, but for Stanley there were graver problems. The natives were not interested in the expedition except to earn money or seize a chance to desert and steal the bales they were carrying. When the going became too tough they dropped away like flies and for the next eight months Stanley had to keep the column together by moral and often physical force.

Men who ran away, men who fell ill with smallpox, dysentery, elephantiasis or malaria, men who collapsed and died on the march, native chiefs who demanded extortionate payment before letting the column pass, savage tribes who waited to fall

shrieking on the travellers and stripped them of all they possessed, starvation, thirst, exhaustion of body and mind—all these troubles lay in wait.

Meanwhile, ten miles from the start, the first of many marshy rivers was encountered where pack-animals had to be unloaded and led over a makeshift bridge of tree trunks and porters sank to their waists in slimy ooze. Then the column went climbing up to a plateau and from there followed a regular caravan route used by Arab traders, moving from village to village where food and water could be obtained. These places were mostly hotbeds of disease and soon Stanley's two horses died and many of the men were ill.

Stanley dosed them and did not hesitate to use a whip when he judged them well enough to move on. Then, rousing the column before dawn with a tattoo on a cooking pan, he led them, on foot himself this time, at a killing pace to their next bivouac.

For several days the expedition trudged southwest and then west through an impressive town called Simbamwenni (recently identified as the modern Morogoro) towards an encampment on the far side where, for the first time of many, the leader went down with malaria. The site, used by generations of Arab traders and their porters, was filthy and Stanley, tossing with fever in his tent, was plagued by armies of ants and centipedes.

For two months Stanley passed his apprenticeship in African travel and by May the worst physical difficulties were over when the expedition reached higher land beyond the Usagara mountains. There he joined an Arab convoy for safety, but their combined forces were soon attacked by hostile tribes, while Stanley again went down with fever. With his well-armed men he was not afraid of enemy spears, but endless haggling over tribute at tribal boundaries exasperated him and more than once his hot temper nearly led to disaster. But the worst trial of all was still to come. At Tabora, a township about 200 miles east of Lake Tanganyika, Stanley received devastating news; over all the country between him and his goal a full-scale war was in progress with an African chief named Mirambo, who had blocked the caravan route to Ujiji and was laying waste the

region. Stanley lent his men to fight with the Arabs against him. Most of them were killed. Stanley collapsed with fever again. Then Mirambo attacked Tabora; Stanley prepared for a last-ditch defence—and was saved by Mirambo drawing off with his booty-laden warriors.

After three months in Tabora, Stanley set off again with fresh recruits, and to avoid the battle area took a wide detour to the south through unknown country which tripled the remaining distance to Ujiji. Several men succumbed to smallpox and fever; others deserted and capturing them, Stanley flogged them and chained them together. His iron will drove the party on, mastering even a mutiny when he was in danger of his life.

Then came a country rich in game. There was an orgy of hunting and eating, and though stricken with fever again, Stanley began to feel that he might, after all, reach Ujiji. But was Livingstone there? Days later at a village he heard a rumour from travellers that a white man was somewhere ahead of him.

The news was vague, but enough to make Stanley's heart beat faster. Because there was still danger from hostile tribes he plunged into uninhabited country, part thick forest, part marsh and ravine, where he sank up to his neck in deep holes and then marched on, a mud pie on two legs, thinking it indecent to take off his clothes. The natives no doubt had a good laugh, but they admired and feared him and followed him willingly, now, even existing for some time on sweetened tea when there was an absence of game.

Weeks passed till, sixty miles short of Ujiji, an African caravan coming from the opposite direction reported that a white man with a grey beard had just arrived there. "Hurrah" wrote Stanley in his diary. "This is Livingstone. He must be Livingstone. He can be no other.... But we must now march quick, lest he hears that we are coming and runs away..."

Marching "quick", the column soon landed in more trouble. The self-styled "king" of the Waha tribe, whose territory had to be crossed, demanded a ruinous tribute which, rather than pit his men against an overwhelming horde, Stanley paid—only to find the next village on the route forewarned and the king's brother clamouring for equal payment.

But five more villages lay ahead where more rolls of cloth could have to be handed over and Stanley simply could not meet this new demand. If he refused, on the other hand, the savages would descend and pillage his column to the bone. The only alternataive was flight—and in the darkness one night, guided by two deserted slaves, he and his men crept away and by forced marches over plains and hills escaped from the Waha country.

Then came picturesque valleys, wild fruit-trees and beautiful flowers. The men were in high spirits. Ujiji lay ahead, and from a mountain spur came the first glimpse of Lake Tanganyika. Stanley was overwhelmed. But Livingstone? Already with pounding heart Stanley had ordered a servant to lay out his new flannel suit, oil his boots, chalk his helmet and fit a new puggaree "that I may make as presentable an appearance as possible before the white man with the grey beard."

The "braves" strode away light-heartedly down the mountain-side towards the town and while still a mile away, Stanley ordered the column to close up, the American flag to be held aloft at the front, the Zanzibar flag at the rear and as was customary, repeated volleys to be fired to announce the arrival of the caravan.

The people of Ujiji rushed up to meet and welcome him. Suddenly Stanley heard a voice say, "Good morning, Sir" and turning saw a native with a gleaming row of white teeth.

"And who the mischief are you?"

"I am Susi, the servant of Dr. Livingstone."

Susi ran back to tell his master and the column moved towards Livingstone's house where a crowd was already collecting. A slim, grey-bearded figure came out. "I see the doctor, Sir" said Stanley's servant.

At this moment Stanley suddenly felt uncertain. The doctor was an educated man from the British Isles where Stanley had suffered so much. How would he receive the workhouse brat? Stanley had indeed performed miracles. He had blazed a trail, brought needed supplies hundreds of miles, and braved death many times. But still he could not be sure. "I did not know", he wrote later, how he would receive me; so I did what cowardice

and false pride suggested---was the best thing---walked deliberately to him, took off my hat, and said: "Dr. Livingstone. I presume?"

But the doctor was kind, and grateful and did not even mind that Stanley represented the *New York Herald* and with him in the next few weeks Stanley came to know the meaning of veneration, while in his heart, fanned by Livingstone's great example, burst into full fame the love of African exploration which was never to leave him.